

Avast! 4 Home Edition

Many home users would think twice about spending for an antivirus package. After all, paying a decent sum on a yearly basis to protect data that may not be as important to them isn't exactly a very good idea. That's where the beauty of freeware comes in. Yes, Avast! is free for home usage and you can check it out on the *Digit DVD*.

While freeware, to most people, usually translates to an amateurishly made home project by a pimply faced teenager, we assure you that's not the case here. Avast! antivirus features outstanding malware detection abilities, together with high performance. The interface is simple and easy to follow for most purposes. There's also an option to skin the interface just in case you want to give your antivirus a new look. Why you would want to do that to an antivirus, however, is beyond us.

The antivirus consists of a real-time scanner that scans files for viruses on access, on demand or on schedule. There's also a real-time scanner for your incoming e-mail, which prevents e-mail-based viruses and worms before they get a chance to act up. However, the e-mail functionality is offered for Microsoft Outlook only.

The virus scanner is based on an intelligent heuristic system that detects viruses on your computer and your e-mails. Virus definitions are regularly updated and Avast! intelligently connects to the server and automatically downloads the updates (which are generally quite tiny) whenever you connect to the Internet.

Pros: Free; light on the system and very effective against viruses.

Cons: Barebones antivirus with no frills such as a firewall or spyware scanner.

